

Semiotics and Structuralism

Both Roland Barthes and Claude Lévi-Strauss are French scholars, the former a literary theorist and the latter an anthropologist, who were involved in refining the arguments behind the fields of thought eventually termed **structuralism** and **semiotics**. At its core, **structuralism** is the argument that only through studying how different aspects of culture are related to one another can we understand the elements that structure societies. Lévi-Strauss was particularly influential in developing structuralism as a primary mechanism for anthropological inquiry. In his work on food, such as the essay on the culinary triangle that you read here, you can see his structuralist approach through the way he uses structures of language to provide a structural analogy to the methods of food preparation detailed in the final culinary triangle of the raw, the cooked, and the rotted. Notice how Lévi-Strauss uses principles of comparison to uncover the elements that structure societal norms or conventions.

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Barthes uses a discussion of French versus American attitudes toward sugar to introduce his main point: that food is a language of communication that is structured within societies just as is verbal language. He defines communication as a “system of signification, that is, a body of discrete signs standing out from a mass of indifferent materials” (p. 26). Barthes thus turns to investigating how foods serve as signs within French society, in particular, but human societies more generally.

Both Lévi-Strauss and Barthes use **semiotics**, the study of signs and signification, as a key component of their arguments. Compare Barthes’s discussion of the term “crisp” with his discussion of food as a symbol of power to gain insight into two modes of semiotic argument. Lévi-Strauss’s construction of the relationship between boiled and rotted food is similar in its discussion of the symbolic meaning of these modes of food preparation among different cultures.

Semiotics is the study of signs, symbols, and their meaning. Often, semiotics involves the study of the meanings of specific words and terms.

Materialism

In his essay on the “abominable pig,” Marvin Harris moves from semiotic interpretations of pigs as forbidden to consider instead a materialist explanation for their proscription. **Materialism** is the study of behavior and culture as being rooted not in symbols and their meaning but instead in the interplay between different substances and physical properties. In this perspective, cultural restrictions on pig consumption originate from practical concerns about the ecology of pigs in the habitat of the Israelites. Compare his arguments with those of Mary Douglas, which he cites on page 62, as being rooted in semiotic concerns about the symbolism of the pig as a “thing out of place.”

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Race and Place

The contemporary scholars Psyche Williams-Forsen, James R. Veteto, and Edward M. Maclin have different concerns in their writing. Williams-Forsen uses a detailed investigation of a Chris Rock comedy routine that employs food stereotypes about the role of chicken in African American culture to consider Black discourse on both gender roles and racial stereotypes. In this essay, she asks, “What do we learn about African Americans when black people willingly engage in perpetuating the oversimplified images or ideas that are sometimes held by the larger American society?” (p. 108) and uses food as the lens through which to do so.

Veteto and Maclin’s essay opens their book *The Slow and the Slow Cooked: Culture and Barbecue in the Mid-South*. The title is, as you probably recognize, a play on Lévi-Strauss’s culinary triangle and the opposition of the raw and the cooked, which is the title of a book originally published in 1964. Veteto and Maclin’s book focuses on one particular region of the US, the Mid-South, which they define as encompassing portions of Tennessee, Arkansas, Kentucky, and Louisiana. For these authors, barbeque is the ultimate expression of place in the South, serving to identify where someone is from and thus what their cultural, as well as culinary, traditions may be. Barbeque serves as a ritualized form of intercommunity competition and a centerpiece of community myth and history (as in the origin of McClard’s Bar-B-Q sauce). Barbeque is thus a worthy subject of anthropological study, just as is the role of chicken in a Chris Rock routine.